

An Inglorious

By S. Prasannarajan

The loneliest man of Indian politics dreads to step out of the walls that separate him from the horror that multiplies outside the haunted fortress that is 30 Prithviraj Road in Lutyens' Delhi. Open the windows and he hears the whispers of the Undead who have swarmed the leafy lanes. They are waiting to claim him, and their voice has the unmistakable tone of vengeance and anger, hurt and humiliation. He dare not look. Oh, those creepy figures without shadows, and he knows who they are, where they come from, and what makes them hungry. They are all there, he is darn sure. That lanky fellow from Karachi, still exuding his impeccable Savile Row elegance and chomping on the damp half of a cigar, seems to have left the mausoleum back home for good and found a more rewarding haunt across the border. Alongside the founder of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan is the soldier in olive green who carries within him the harshness and endurance of the desert, and he is waving a hardback and crying "Honour". There are more of them, the wounded, the defeated, the marginalised, and even some bearded chaps from Godforsaken Kandahar. Their accusatory fingers are growing frighteningly longer, as if they might even pierce the concrete and touch his allegedly frozen conscience. Lal Krishna Advani can only shudder and retreat further into the shrinking shell of his political existence.

This is not the place he thought he would end up after such a long journey. A place of isolation and rejection. And this is not what he imagined he would become. A superannuated

THE BEST OF ADVANI, WHOSE POLITICAL CAREER